

The Road Not Taken: College Board Geomarkets and Recruiting Visits
by Selective Colleges

1 Research questions

Research interest: performativity (MacKenzie and Millo 2003) in the relationship between College Board Geomarkets, the Market Segment Model, and patterns of recruiting visits to high schools.

1. Do College Board Geomarkets (X) explain which high schools receive recruiting visits (Y) from public research and selective private institutions?
2. To what extent are visit patterns consistent with recommendations from the Market Segment Model?
3. Does Geomarket popularity (Z) mediate the relationship between school composition (X; %free reduced lunch; %Black/Hispanic) and probability of a high school getting a visit (Y)?

2 Front end

2.1 Dependence and Patronage in the Enrollment Economy

- Dependence (Pfeffer and Salancik 1978) and patronage (Stevens and Gebre-Medhin 2016)
- “Enrollment economy” from Clark (1956) and Winston (1999); sketch enrollment economy for sample
 - 12 selective private liberal arts colleges; 14 selective private research universities
 - 16 public research universities; from “national service” patronage to reliance on same enrollment economy as selective privates (Jaquette and Curs 2015; Jaquette et al. 2024)
- Enrollment management (EM) is responsible for stable flow of resources (students); colleges depend on high schools – dyadic relationships – to provide these students
- Scholarship on recruiting that focuses on linkages between colleges and high schools
 - Coopt dependencies that cannot be acquired/substituted (Stevens 2007; Khan 2010)
 - Scholarship on recruiting (Salazar et al. 2021; Salazar 2022; Jaquette et al. 2024) incorrectly assumes that EM behavior is a function of *individual* colleges, conditioned by macro logics

2.2 The Case: Geomarkets and the Market Segment Model

- Geomarkets and Market Segment Model developed by Zemsky and Oedel (1983)
- Origins in concerns about demographics; involve membership orgs COFHE + College Board
- Categorize students into four “market segments” based on SAT score-sending; creation of Geomarkets
- Market Segment Model: social class determines demand for specific college located in specific place
 - Class composition varies by Geomarket; implications for which Geomarkets to recruit from

2.3 Market Devices, Commensuration, and Classification

Introduce salient concepts/literatures and pepper-in additional context about the case

- *Market devices* (Muniesa et al. 2007; MacKenzie and Millo 2003; Krippner 2024)
 - Market devices useful for shifting attention to individual components – techniques, theories, cultural logics, histories – foundational to products and markets
 - Geomarkets and Market Segment Model are market devices that build on SAT
 - Performativity; options prices began behaving like Black-Scholes model because logic of model built into trading software (MacKenzie and Millo 2003);
 - * Similarly, logic of Market Segment Model – a class-based theory of geography of student demand – built into College Board Enrollment Planning Service (EPS) software
- *Commensuration* (Espeland and Stevens 1998; Fourcade 2011)
 - Analysis of UK school “league tables” (McArthur and Reeves 2022); commensuration as a mechanism of social reproduction
 - SAT as a market device that facilitates commensuration (Hoxby 2009);
 - Geomarkets are a commensurating market device that enables colleges to compare geographic localities based on class composition and number of students from each market segment
- *Ordinalization and classification situations* (Fourcade and Healy 2013, 2024, 2017; Fourcade 2016)
 - Fourcade (2016) defines three kinds of classification; ascendance of ordinal classifications
 - Classification situations (Fourcade and Healy 2013)
 - * goal of classification situations is “good matches” between ordinal hierarchy of products and ordinal hierarchy of consumers
 - * Market Segment Model as ordinal market device that amplifies inequality; class-based hierarchy of students matched to class-based hierarchy of colleges
- Hook; most scholarship on quantification in sociology of education focuses on third-parties that classify producers/sellers on behalf of consumers (e.g., college/school rankings)
 - Scholarship shows how orgs (Ray 2019), schools (Domina et al. 2017) reproduce inequality
 - Empirical scholarship in sociology of education fails to consider third-party intermediaries – along the lines of classification situations – that classify students on behalf of colleges

2.4 RQs and Expected Results

Expected results speak to performativity consequences of Geomarkets and Market Segment Model

- **RQ1:** Do college board Geomarkets explain which high schools receive recruiting visits from public research and selective private PSIs?
 - Expect Geomarkets explain recruiting visits, even after strong controls, because Geomarkets/Market Segment Model are basis for popular EPS software and because colleges often used Geomarkets to define recruiting territories
 - Table X shows results from fixed effects regressions [CRYSTAL]
- **RQ2:** To what extent are visit patterns consistent with recommendations from the Market Segment?
 - We expect that recruiting visit patterns of most colleges are consistent with Market Segment Model recommendations of **(A)** a regional/national recruiting strategy that **(B)** focuses on high schools in affluent Geomarkets
 - **RQ2A:** Figure 1 shows geography of 2016 freshman enrollment for sample; Figure 2 shows 2017 recruiting by local, in-state, regional, national markets; Figure 3 shows 2017 recruiting by EPS region (New England; Middle States; Midwest; South; Southwest; West)
 - **RQ2B:** Table X and Y, [CRYSTAL] respectively, show top-30 Geomarkets for visits to public schools and private schools; Figure 4 shows Lorenz-style concentration curves of recruiting visits by Geomarket affluence
- **RQ3:** Does geomarket popularity (Z) mediate the relationship between school composition (X; % free reduced lunch; % Black/Hispanic) and probability of a high school getting a visit (Y)?
 - Question is about which schools benefit from being located in a popular Geomarket (measured by number of visits per school): high-SES vs. low-SES schools; low vs. high %Black/Hispanic
 - * We expect that high SES schools and low %Black/Hispanic schools will benefit more from being in a popular Geomarket because these schools are a “good match” with popular Geomarket whereas poor/minority schools are a bad match
 - * Fourcade and Healy (2017, 17): “‘good matches’ are perceived as natural because they fit well with how things already are.”
 - Table X [CRYSTAL] shows fixed effects regression model with interaction between Geomarket popularity and school SES/racial composition

3 References

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4 Appendix

- NOT CLEAR WHETHER YOU SHOULD CREATE CAPTION IN THE .QMD FILE OR IN THE TEX FILE.

term	(1) Univ $\times$ State FE	(2) Univ $\times$ EPS FE	(3) Covar + Univ FE	(4) Covar + Univ $\times$ State FE	(5) Covar + Univ $\times$ EPS FE
hs_controlprivate			-0.025*** (0.004)	-0.021*** (0.004)	-0.020*** (0.004)
hs_g11			0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)
hs_controlprivate $\times$ hs_g11			0.001*** (0.000)	0.001*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)
hs_pct_asian			-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)
hs_pct_black			-0.000** (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)
hs_pct_hispanic			-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)
hs_pct_amerindian			0.000 (0.000)	0.000* (0.000)	0.000* (0.000)
hs_pct_nativehawaii			0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000* (0.000)
hs_pct_tworaces			0.000* (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)
hs_overall_niche_letter_gradeA+			0.151*** (0.012)	0.154*** (0.012)	0.152*** (0.012)
hs_overall_niche_letter_gradeA			0.031*** (0.005)	0.033*** (0.005)	0.034*** (0.005)
hs_overall_niche_letter_gradeA-			0.007** (0.002)	0.009*** (0.002)	0.010*** (0.002)
hs_overall_niche_letter_gradeB+			0.004* (0.001)	0.005** (0.002)	0.005*** (0.001)
hs_overall_niche_letter_gradeB			0.001 (0.001)	0.002 (0.002)	0.003 (0.001)
hs_overall_niche_letter_gradeB-			-0.001 (0.001)	0.000 (0.002)	0.000 (0.001)
hs_overall_niche_letter_gradeC+			-0.001 (0.001)	-0.000 (0.001)	-0.000 (0.001)
hs_overall_niche_letter_gradeC			-0.000 (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)
hs_overall_niche_letter_gradeC-			-0.000 (0.001)	-0.003* (0.001)	-0.003* (0.001)
hs_zip_inc_house_mean_decileD2			0.002 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)
hs_zip_inc_house_mean_decileD3			0.002 (0.002)	-0.000 (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)
hs_zip_inc_house_mean_decileD4			0.003 (0.003)	0.001 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)
hs_zip_inc_house_mean_decileD5			0.003 (0.003)	-0.000 (0.002)	-0.000 (0.002)

(continued)

term	(1) Univ × State FE	(2) Univ × EPS FE	(3) Covar + Univ FE	(4) Covar + Univ × State FE	(5) Covar + Univ × EPS FE
hs_zip_inc_house_mean_decileD6			0.005 (0.003)	0.000 (0.002)	0.000 (0.002)
hs_zip_inc_house_mean_decileD7			0.006 (0.004)	0.001 (0.002)	-0.000 (0.002)
hs_zip_inc_house_mean_decileD8			0.007 (0.005)	-0.001 (0.003)	-0.002 (0.002)
hs_zip_inc_house_mean_decileD9			0.011 (0.006)	0.002 (0.002)	0.001 (0.003)
hs_zip_inc_house_mean_decileD10			0.035*** (0.009)	0.026*** (0.005)	0.023*** (0.005)
hs_zip_pct_edu_baplus_all_decileD2			-0.001 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)	-0.000 (0.001)
hs_zip_pct_edu_baplus_all_decileD3			-0.001 (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)	-0.002** (0.001)
hs_zip_pct_edu_baplus_all_decileD4			-0.000 (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)	-0.002 (0.001)
hs_zip_pct_edu_baplus_all_decileD5			0.000 (0.001)	-0.001 (0.002)	-0.002 (0.001)
hs_zip_pct_edu_baplus_all_decileD6			-0.001 (0.002)	-0.002 (0.002)	-0.002 (0.002)
hs_zip_pct_edu_baplus_all_decileD7			-0.000 (0.002)	-0.000 (0.002)	-0.001 (0.002)
hs_zip_pct_edu_baplus_all_decileD8			-0.000 (0.003)	0.000 (0.003)	-0.002 (0.003)
hs_zip_pct_edu_baplus_all_decileD9			0.005 (0.005)	0.005 (0.003)	0.002 (0.003)
hs_zip_pct_edu_baplus_all_decileD10			0.033*** (0.008)	0.034*** (0.006)	0.027*** (0.005)
hs_zip_pct_pov_yes			0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)
I(hs_zip_pct_pov_yes2)			-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)
hs_zip_pct_nhisp_black			0.000* (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)
hs_zip_pct_nhisp_native			0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)
hs_zip_pct_nhisp_asian			0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)
hs_zip_pct_nhisp_nhpi			0.005** (0.002)	0.001 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)
hs_zip_pct_nhisp_multi			0.001 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)
hs_zip_pct_hisp_all			0.000* (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)

(continued)

term	(1) Univ × State FE	(2) Univ × EPS FE	(3) Covar + Univ FE	(4) Covar + Univ × State FE	(5) Covar + Univ × EPS FE
hs_univ_dist			(0.000)	(0.000)	(0.000)
			-0.000***	-0.000**	-0.000
			(0.000)	(0.000)	(0.000)
N	995,568	995,568	982,128	982,128	982,128
Adj. R²	0.099	0.169	0.137	0.212	0.260
Within R²	0.000	0.000	0.130	0.125	0.108
RMSE	0.166	0.158	0.163	0.155	0.150

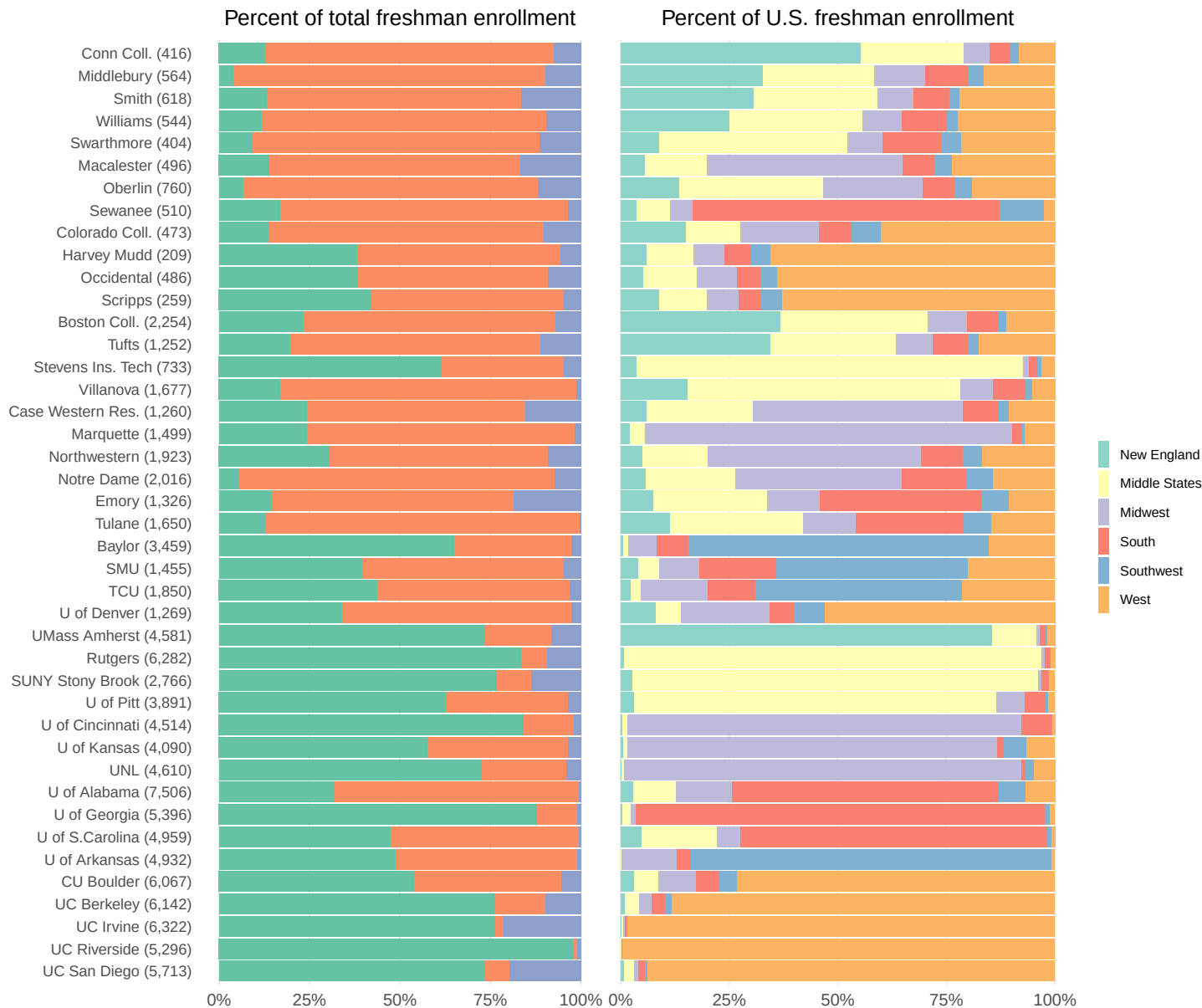


Figure 1: Geographic origin of fall 2016 freshman enrollment

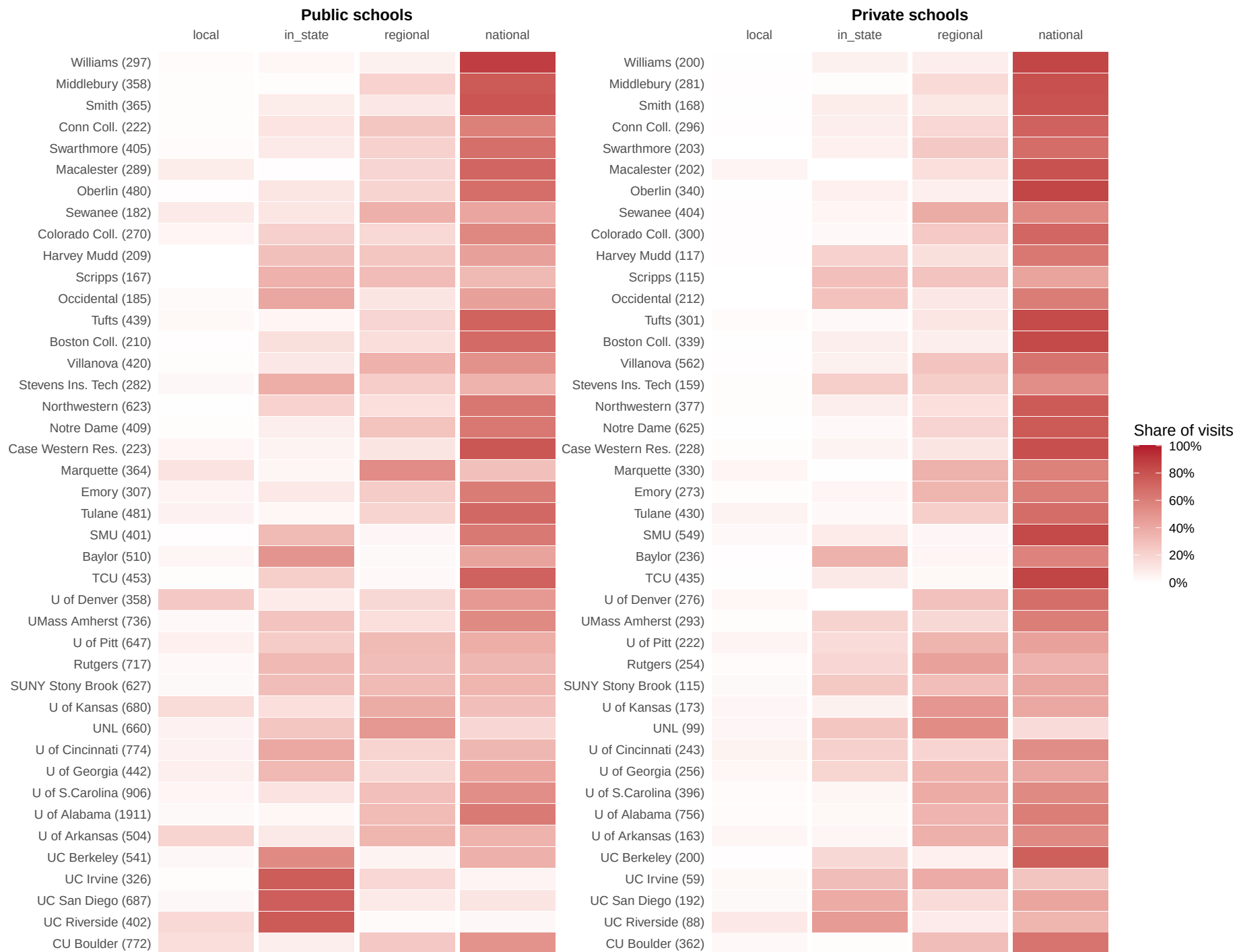


Figure 2: Recruiting visits by market segment of Geomarket

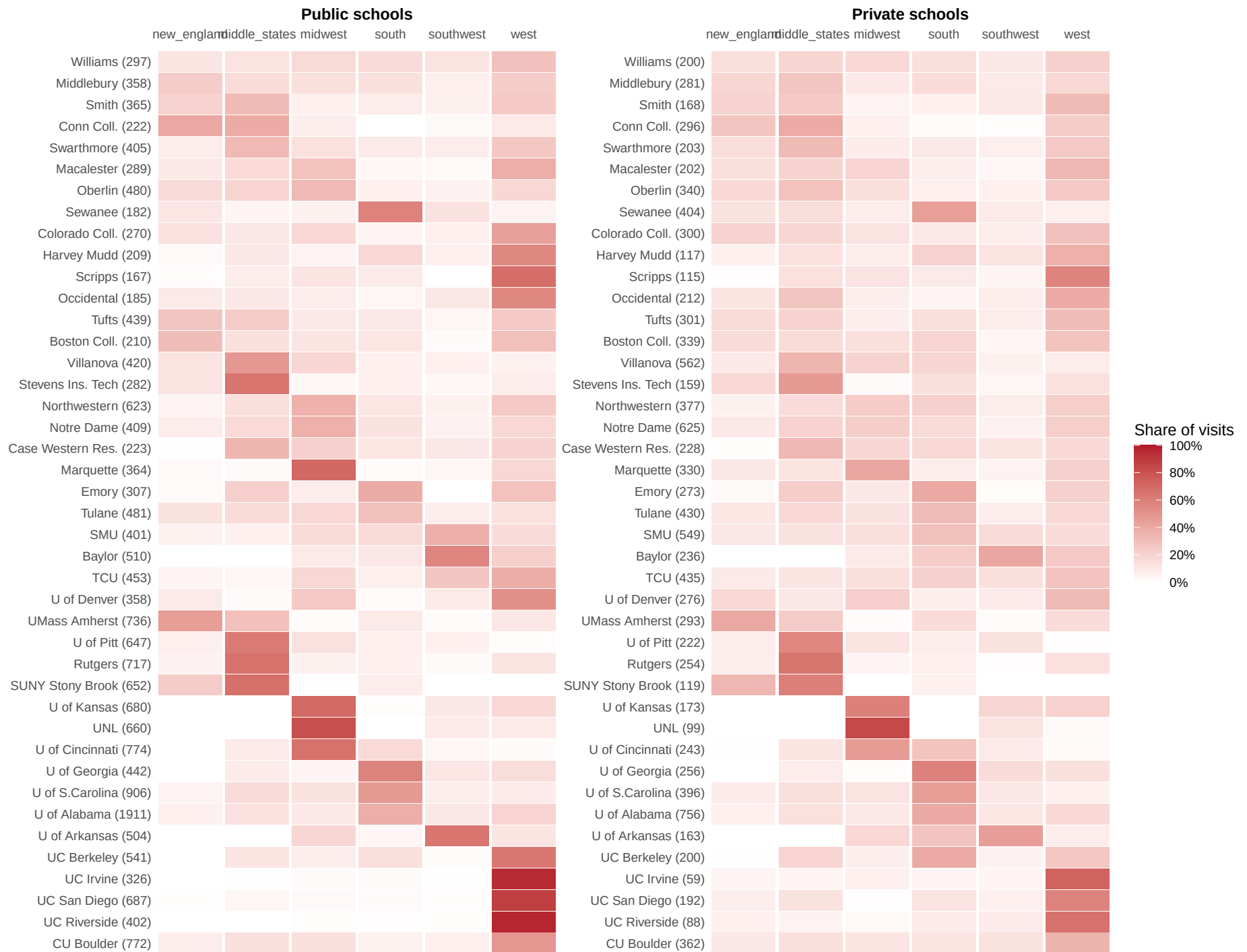


Figure 3: Recruiting visits by EPS region

Table 2: Top 30 Geomarkets ranked by visits per school (public school visits only)

Rank	EPS	Visits/Sch	MeanInc	%BA+	%Pov	%White	%Asian	%Black	%Hisp
1	IL 9 - North Shore	24.5	\$259k	73.5	5.6	79.0	9.6	1.9	7.2
2	IL10 - Evanston & Skokie	17.0	\$156k	58.3	8.4	64.6	17.7	5.1	9.4
3	VA 1 - Arlington & Alexandria	11.6	\$175k	71.4	6.6	57.1	8.8	13.9	15.8
4	TX23 - Collin & Rockwall Co	11.2	\$146k	52.3	6.0	56.8	14.5	9.4	15.6
5	IL 8 - Northwest Suburbs	11.0	\$126k	44.7	6.8	58.2	15.0	3.3	20.8
6	MD 2 - Montgomery Metropolitan	10.4	\$165k	59.2	6.6	43.1	14.9	18.0	19.5
7	VA 2 - Fairfax Co	10.3	\$182k	62.3	5.4	50.4	19.6	9.3	16.2
8	IL12 - Western Suburbs	10.3	\$134k	46.9	6.8	60.3	10.5	8.1	18.5
9	CT 3 - Fairfield Co	9.9	\$160k	48.9	8.7	61.0	5.3	10.6	20.0
10	IL 7 - Chain of Lakes	9.7	\$125k	39.7	8.4	57.2	7.4	7.5	25.1
11	CA11 - Santa Clara Co (excluding San Jose)	9.6	\$234k	64.3	5.7	36.8	39.4	1.8	17.1
12	CO 2 - Metro Denver & Northeastern Colorado	9.4	\$121k	44.8	8.7	66.2	3.8	4.3	22.1
13	CA 4 - Marin Co	9.0	\$190k	60.2	6.6	70.6	5.7	2.1	16.1
14	NY17 - Northern Nassau Co	8.8	\$266k	62.4	6.7	67.7	16.9	2.3	10.6
15	NJ 6 - Somerset & Mercer Co	8.8	\$155k	49.3	8.5	51.8	14.6	14.8	16.4
16	CA28 - South Orange Co	8.2	\$177k	56.7	7.2	57.4	19.5	1.4	16.5
17	CA17 - West Los Angeles & West Beach	8.2	\$155k	60.3	11.1	50.3	11.9	9.6	22.5
18	MA10 - Milton, Lexington, & Waltham	8.1	\$181k	64.0	5.8	74.2	13.1	3.4	6.0
19	GA 2 - Fulton Co	7.7	\$116k	54.5	12.3	39.3	7.3	43.1	7.2
20	NY19 - Northwest Suffolk Co	7.7	\$182k	47.7	4.6	76.9	5.9	3.0	12.0
21	CA 6 - Contra Costa Co	7.2	\$151k	43.3	8.1	42.6	17.2	8.2	25.8
22	CA26 - Santa Ana	7.0	\$131k	36.5	10.4	35.1	21.1	1.1	38.9
23	TX24 - West of Dallas/Ft. Worth Metroplex	6.9	\$124k	41.3	6.9	62.6	6.9	8.9	17.9
24	NJ11 - Morris & Northern Passaic Co	6.8	\$173k	53.4	5.3	71.8	9.7	2.9	13.2
25	NJ10 - Bergen Co	6.7	\$159k	50.7	7.2	55.5	16.4	5.3	20.4
26	CA 8 - Alameda Co (w/o Oakland)	6.7	\$165k	49.3	7.6	31.0	36.4	6.0	20.8
27	NJ 7 - Union Co	6.6	\$114k	37.1	8.9	39.0	5.2	20.2	32.0
28	PA 4 - Montgomery Co	6.6	\$142k	49.6	6.2	74.9	7.7	9.1	5.3
29	CA20 - South Bay	6.5	\$126k	44.6	8.9	31.7	21.8	9.8	31.7
30	MA 8 - Lowell, Concord, & Wellesley	6.5	\$160k	51.6	7.2	75.0	10.7	3.4	7.4

Table 3: Top 30 Geomarkets ranked by visits per school (private school visits only)

Rank	EPS	Visits/Sch	MeanInc	%BA+	%Pov	%White	%Asian	%Black	%Hisp
1	IL 9 - North Shore	31.0	\$259k	73.5	5.6	79.0	9.6	1.9	7.2
2	TX19 - City of Dallas	22.4	\$81k	34.9	15.6	29.8	3.4	22.9	41.7
3	IL10 - Evanston & Skokie	20.3	\$156k	58.3	8.4	64.6	17.7	5.1	9.4
4	TX20 - City of Fort Worth	20.2	\$91k	28.3	12.1	42.0	4.4	15.8	34.8
5	CA 7 - City of Oakland	19.5	\$124k	47.0	13.4	29.6	15.7	21.7	26.3
6	IL 7 - Chain of Lakes	19.0	\$125k	39.7	8.4	57.2	7.4	7.5	25.1
7	VA 1 - Arlington & Alexandria	18.8	\$175k	71.4	6.6	57.1	8.8	13.9	15.8
8	CA 4 - Marin Co	17.7	\$190k	60.2	6.6	70.6	5.7	2.1	16.1
9	DC 1 - District of Columbia	17.0	\$155k	59.8	13.7	36.7	4.0	44.5	11.1
10	TX16 - Southwest Houston Metro Area	16.6	\$106k	46.8	11.8	31.5	16.1	20.0	29.6
11	CA29 - North San Diego Co (w/o San Diego)	16.0	\$144k	44.1	8.0	52.3	10.4	2.3	29.8
12	CT 4 - Waterbury & Litchfield Co	16.0	\$129k	35.9	7.2	87.6	1.9	1.5	6.6
13	NH 1 - Seacoast	16.0	\$138k	44.5	7.1	91.2	3.0	0.9	2.3
14	GA 2 - Fulton Co	14.9	\$116k	54.5	12.3	39.3	7.3	43.1	7.2
15	CA28 - South Orange Co	14.2	\$177k	56.7	7.2	57.4	19.5	1.4	16.5
16	CT 5 - Hartford & Tolland Co	14.1	\$117k	39.0	11.0	63.5	5.4	11.4	16.6
17	CA31 - City of San Diego	14.0	\$118k	45.4	11.4	44.7	14.7	6.8	28.9
18	MA 7 - Quincy & Plymouth Co	13.2	\$137k	38.6	7.5	80.2	1.4	8.9	4.0
19	TX 6 - Austin & Central Texas	13.1	\$114k	43.0	9.4	53.7	5.0	6.4	31.9
20	NY19 - Northwest Suffolk Co	13.0	\$182k	47.7	4.6	76.9	5.9	3.0	12.0
21	OH 5 - Cuyahoga, Geauga, & Lake Co	12.8	\$106k	36.4	7.1	87.2	2.3	4.6	3.5
22	OR 1 - Greater Portland (West)	12.8	\$130k	53.6	9.4	69.6	9.0	3.3	12.1
23	MO 1 - Kansas City & St. Joseph	12.6	\$84k	28.7	11.9	76.0	1.5	11.9	6.7
24	NJ 6 - Somerset & Mercer Co	12.2	\$155k	49.3	8.5	51.8	14.6	14.8	16.4
25	CA15 - San Fernando Valley (East)	12.1	\$123k	51.6	12.0	58.4	6.8	5.1	24.9
26	CO 2 - Metro Denver & Northeastern Colorado	12.0	\$121k	44.8	8.7	66.2	3.8	4.3	22.1
27	MD 2 - Montgomery Metropolitan	11.9	\$165k	59.2	6.6	43.1	14.9	18.0	19.5
28	CA11 - Santa Clara Co (excluding San Jose)	11.6	\$234k	64.3	5.7	36.8	39.4	1.8	17.1
29	CA26 - Santa Ana	11.5	\$131k	36.5	10.4	35.1	21.1	1.1	38.9
30	CT 2 - New Haven & Middlesex Co	11.3	\$118k	37.1	10.8	65.3	3.9	11.3	16.6

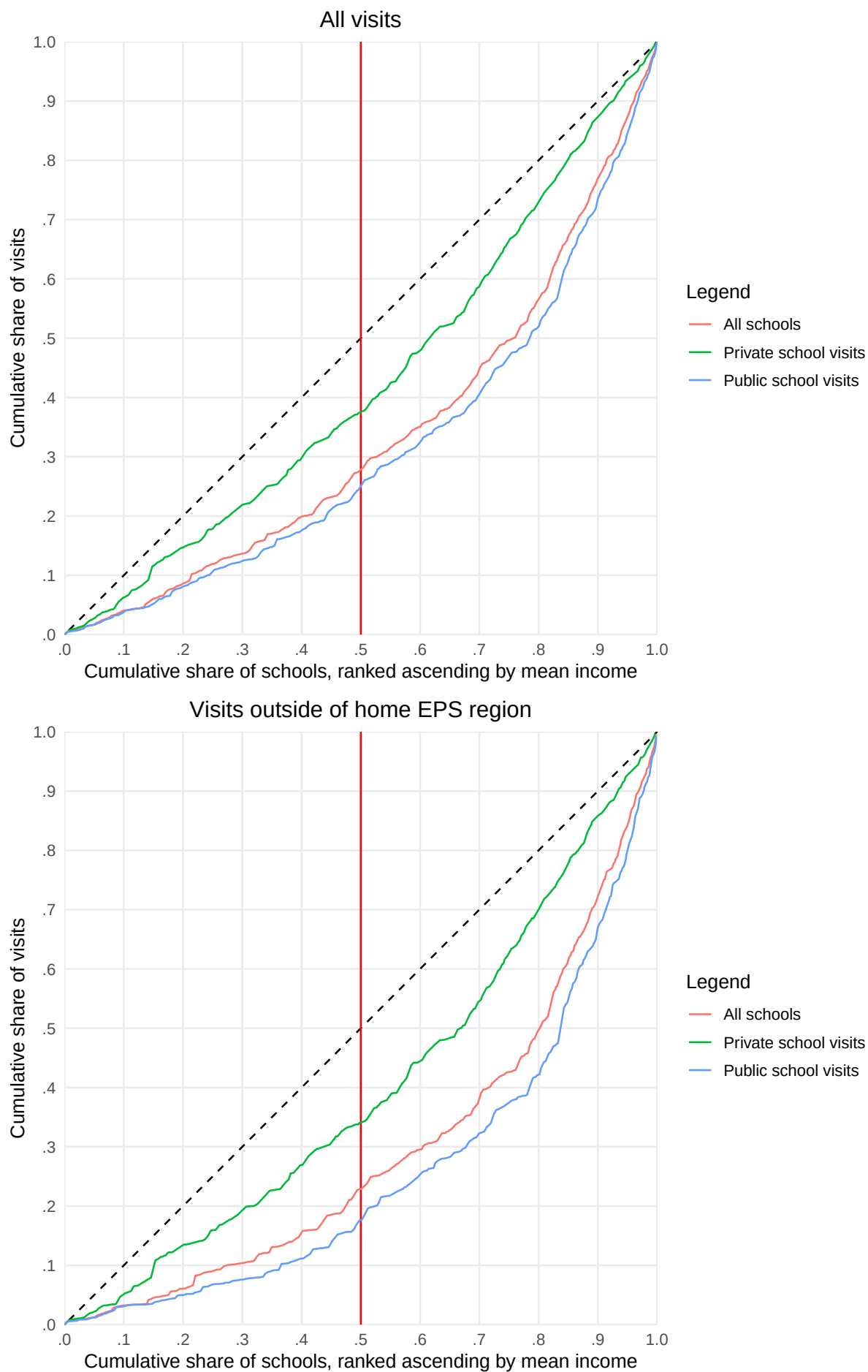


Figure 4: Lorenz-style concentration curves of recruiting visits by Geomarket affluence